The Vigilant Rabbit

By David Sedaris

NARRATOR: **(Pg 98+)** A white-tailed doe was discovered one morning disemboweled on the banks of the stream, and the residents of the forest went crazy with fear

SPARROW: Freaked out!

NARRATOR: A few days later a skunk was found, no more than a gnawed-upon skull attached to a short leash of spine. Personality-wise, he'd been no great shakes. Neither was he particularly good-looking, but still! Then a squirrel disappeared, and it was decided that something had to be done.

INTRODUCTION

There's a huge laundry list of problems on our planet... terrorism, poverty, crime, COVID-19, corruption, immigration, polarized politics, abuse of power . . . This far from comprehensive list goes on. And on. And on. How can we focus on such weighty issues without falling into a pit of despair? By tempering the darkness with a bit of humor. Enter David Sedaris with an interesting take on both immigration and abuse of power.

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NARRATOR: A meeting was convened in the clearing near the big oak, and the hawk, who often flew great distances in search of food, proposed that they build a gate.

HAWK: I've seen one where the humans live, and it seems to work fairly well.

MUSKRAT: *(Raising his paw)* Work how?

NARRATOR: The hawk explained that once the gate was erected, anyone entering the forest would have to stop and identify himself.

HAWK: It keeps out the riffraff. When bad things happen, that is usually who is responsible – riffraff.

MUSKRAT: *(Raising his paw again)* And what if this riffraff can't be stopped?

HAWK: Then you sound an alarm. It could be anything, really, just so long as it's loud.

NARRATOR: The building of the gate was left to the beaver, who had a slight problem with the hinges, but eventually got them right. Just to the side of them he hung a gong fashioned from an old NO TRESPASSING sign.

BEAVER: I figured I could hit it with my tail. *(Giving it a whack for good measure and it echoes)*

RABBIT: *(stepping forward)* Who elected you to man the gate? Anyone could hit a sheet of rusted metal, even someone without an oversize tail. *(he picks up a heavy stick and goes at it, creating a racket as loud as the beaver's)* I've also got better hearing! I'm slimmer, I'm faster, and I'm more safety conscious, *vigilant*, you might say.

BEAVER: Whatever! *(and he waddles off)*

NARRATOR: On the rabbit's first morning as chief of security, he stopped an approaching snake.

SNAKE: *(looking up at Rabbit and laughing until he cries)*

RABBIT: Something funny?.

SNAKE: *(wiping a tear from his face with his tail)* You idiots! What good is a gate without a wall?

RABBIT: What good is a… *huh*?

SNAKE: It doesn't make any sense. If an animal doesn't want to enter here, what's to stop him from moving down a few dozen yards and crawling in beside the fallen pine?

RABBIT: What's to stop him? *(he picks up his heavy stick and bashes the snake's head in)*

NARRATOR: Then he kicked some dirt over the body and wrote NO LAUGHING on the NO TRESPASSING sign.

NARRATOR: A short while later a magpie stopped by and pecked at the bits of brain left scattered on the ground in front of the gate.

MAGPIE: *(between mouthfuls)* Not to nitpick, but what's to prevent someone from entering by air? You and your friends initiate a no-fly zone?

RABBIT: What's to keep you from flying in? *(and once again he brings down his heavy stick)*

NARRATOR: Then he dug up the snake and hung both it and the dead magpie from the top of his gate. There they could act as visual warnings, proof that he was a force to be reckoned with. When that was done, he added to his sign

RABBIT: *(Reads the sign aloud)* NO TRESPASSING. NO LAUGHING. AND NO STUPID QUESTIONS EITHER. THIS MEANS YOU.

NARRATOR: It was a hot, windless day, and within an hour blowflies arrived and settled on the faces of the two dead animals. Their buzzing attracted a frog.

FROG: *(jumps in from the nearby stream, flicks out his tongue, and dins upon the flies. He then notices the sign.)* Seeing as you don't want jokes or questions, I guess I'll phrase this as a comment. In order to enter through your gate I'll have to stop and go through your tiresome rigmarole. That kind of BS doesn't interest me much, so instead I'm going to return to my stream and swim into your third-rate, beetle-infested forest. *(He turns to leave)*

NARRATOR: And the rabbit, who was nothing if not quick, reached for his heavy stick. Then he hung the frog on his gate and added

RABBIT: *(he speaks aloud as he adds to the sign)* NO CURSING!

NARRATOR: It wasn't long before an otter came along and went for the crushed frog. Then a badger stopped by, attracted by the smell of the dead otter. As the

bodies were heaped upon the gate, it began to tilt. The rabbit propped it up with a fallen branch and then turned his attention to the sign.

RABBIT: *(speaks aloud as he modifies the sign)* NO DIRTY LOOKS. NO QUESTIONING MY INTEGRITY. NO INSULTING REMARKS ABOUT MY EARS OR MY TEETH.

NARRATOR: He was just wondering how to spell "insolence" when a shadow fell, and he looked up to see a magnificent white unicorn. His silky mane curled about his neck in waves the color of buttercups. Equally brilliant was his horn, which looked to be made of gold. At his approach, the rabbit put down his pencil.

RABBIT: State your name and your business.

UNICORN: I'm a unicorn and I come to bring joy to all the forest creatures.

RABBIT: Not with that horn you don't.

UNICORN: I beg your pardon?

RABBIT: I said, lose the weapon.

UNICORN: The horn is what makes me who I am!

RABBIT: Which is unwelcome. Now do as I say or beat it. *(reaching for his stick)*

UNICORN: But happiness follows wherever I go! I can make a rainbow just by flicking my tail. If you won't let me *through* the gate, I'll just jump over it.

NARRATOR: And because he was taller than the rabbit and much more powerful, he did just that.

UNICORN: *(Looking back to the gate)* Sorry, but you didn't leave me any choice.

RABBIT: We'll see about that. *(he spits on the ground)*

NARRATOR: The unicorn spent the late afternoon making rainbows for all the woodland creatures. Then he caused the wildflowers to bloom and conjured up some berries for a hungry box turtle. As the sun set over the treetops, he settled upon a bed of fragrant moss and fell into a deep sleep. The following morning, the songbirds woke him.

UNICORN: *(The unicorn wakes up, yawns and notices a pile of golden shavings scattered across the moss. Then feels his forehead and realizes that his horn has been chewed off)* Who chewed off my horn?

RABBIT: Rules are rules. If I let you trot around with a weapon on your head, I'd have to let everyone do it.

UNICORN: But it had magic powers!

RABBIT: I said, scram!

NARRATOR: The unicorn, just a common everyday horse now, slunk off toward a field of tall grasses. The rabbit watched him go and then turned back to his sign.

RABBIT: Magic powers indeed. I didn't taste anything special. *(he spits on the ground again)*

NARRATOR: Only this time a diamond came out and landed on the ground beside him. That's what he was staring at when the wolves arrived.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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